

LOVEBIRD · AGAPORNIS SPP.

Keep your lovebird the right way from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: cage setup, the single-versus-pair decision, diet, and the routines that keep a lovebird thriving for its full lifespan.

21 pages

Intermediate

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 8 in order before buying anything. Cage size and the single-versus-pair decision on page 7 are the two hardest things to fix after the fact, especially once a pair has already bonded. Decide those first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 15 to buy once.

If your lovebird is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Environment Targets on page 13 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 9 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Page 13: Setup Checklist & Environment Targets | ☐ Page 18: Daily, Weekly, Monthly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 14: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 19: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 17: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 20: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Lovebird husbandry advice online swings between two extremes: treating them like disposable "starter birds," or copying advice meant for much larger parrots. This package reflects current cage-size, diet, and social-needs standards, cross-checked against avian sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Agapornis</i> spp.
Adult size	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 17 cm); 1.5 to 2 oz
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical, up to 20 years with excellent care
Native range	Africa and Madagascar
Diet type	Pellet-forward with fresh vegetables; seeds a smaller supplement, not the base
Cage minimum, single bird	18×18×24 in
Cage minimum, bonded pair	24×18×24 in
Social needs	The single most important decision you'll make, see page 7 before buying

Cost overview

Getting one

\$50 to \$150 for a common color type; \$200 to \$400 or more for rare color mutations, with exceptional individuals reaching \$1,000. Adoption typically runs \$20 to \$100.

Monthly ongoing

\$70 to \$125 for pellets, fresh vegetables, toys, and vet care averaged over the year.

BUDGET FOR THE UNEXPECTED TOO

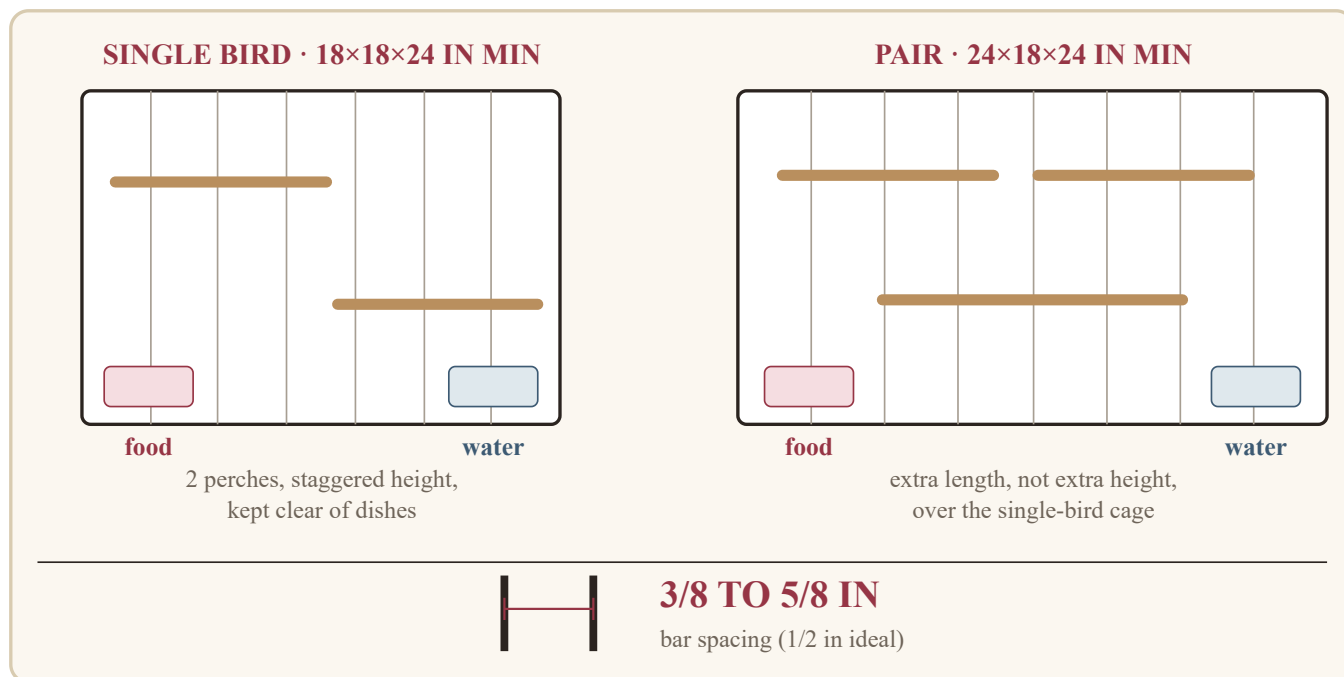
Egg binding and other emergencies need immediate vet care and cost more than the routine \$25 to \$50 checkup. You won't need it if you follow this package, but it's real enough to plan a cushion for.

Fun facts worth knowing

- *Agapornis*, the genus name, comes from Greek for "love bird," a nod to how tightly bonded pairs perch pressed together for hours.
- Lovebirds are native to Africa and Madagascar, not South America or Australia like many commonly kept parrots.
- A well-cared-for lovebird can live up to 20 years, a longer commitment than most owners expect from a bird this small.

Cage size & bar spacing

18×18×24 inches is the minimum for a single bird. A bonded pair needs at least 24×18×24 inches, real extra footprint, not the same cage with a second bird squeezed in. Bar spacing should run 3/8 to 5/8 inch, with 1/2 inch the ideal middle ground: wide enough that the cage doesn't feel like a barrier, narrow enough that a head or foot can't get caught.



What the diagram doesn't show

- Both dimensions are minimums, not targets. More floor space and more length are always fine as long as bar spacing stays in the 3/8 to 5/8 inch range.
- Perches at different heights give a bird somewhere to go besides straight across, and keeping them clear of the dishes keeps droppings out of food and water.
- A pair's extra space is length, not height. A tall, narrow cage doesn't substitute for the added floor and flight room two birds actually need.

Diet & feeding

A lovebird's diet should be pellet-forward with fresh vegetables added daily. Seeds are a smaller supplementary part of the diet, not the base, even though a seed-only bowl is still the default a lot of new owners reach for first.

FOOD	ROLE IN THE DIET	NOTES
Pellets	Base of the diet	Should make up the majority of daily intake
Fresh vegetables	Daily addition	Offered fresh alongside pellets each day
Seeds	Smaller supplement	Not the base, despite being the traditional default

NEVER

Build the diet around seeds. An all-seed or seed-heavy bowl is the single most common feeding mistake with this species, and the most common way pellet-forward guidance ends up ignored in practice.

Making the switch to pellets

A bird raised on seed doesn't always take to pellets right away. Offer both side by side rather than swapping cold, and give it time. This is a gradual transition, not an overnight one, and it's worth the patience given how much of the diet pellets are supposed to make up long term.

Water & dish hygiene

Fresh water daily, in a dish positioned away from perches so droppings don't end up in it. Vegetables spoil faster than pellets in a warm room, so remove anything uneaten rather than letting it sit for hours.

Handling & social needs

This is the single most important decision in this whole package, and it needs to be made before you bring a bird home, not after. Lovebirds are intensely social, but who they bond to depends entirely on whether you keep one bird or two.

CHOICE	WHAT TO ACTUALLY EXPECT	TIME COMMITMENT
Single, hand-raised bird	Can become genuinely tame and interactive with its keeper	Roughly 2 hours of daily interaction to stay well-adjusted
Bonded pair	Bonds to each other, not to you. Largely ignores the owner, closer to keeping a pair of finches than an interactive pet	Minimal direct interaction needed; the birds meet their own social needs

DECIDE BEFORE YOU BUY

You can't undo pair bonding to get an interactive pet back. Once two lovebirds bond to each other, they stay focused on each other, not on you. If you want a bird that interacts with you, get one hand-raised bird. If you want low-maintenance companionship between two birds that entertain each other, get a bonded pair. Trying to have both from the same setup doesn't work.

Why this happens

Parrots are flock animals and need a social bond with something. A single bird without a same-species companion will bond to its human keeper as a substitute flock, which is what makes it affectionate and interactive, but only if the keeper actually shows up for that role. A bonded pair fulfills that same social need with each other, which is easier on a busy household but means the birds stay essentially standoffish toward people.

If you choose a single bird

Roughly 2 hours of daily interaction is what keeps a single, hand-raised lovebird well-adjusted. That's a real daily commitment, not a one-time bonding period you graduate out of. A single bird left alone for long stretches without that interaction is missing the social contact it would otherwise be getting from a mate.

Common mistakes & enrichment

NEVER

Give a pet, non-breeding lovebird a nest box or "happy hut" style covered sleeping tent. These are among the most common and avoidable triggers for hormonal aggression and chronic egg-laying in this species (see page 10). A plain, breathable cage cover for nighttime is fine. Nest-like enclosed furnishings are not.

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Buying two birds expecting an interactive pet, then feeling ignored once they bond to each other instead of the owner.
- Buying a single bird and underestimating the roughly 2 hours of daily interaction it needs to stay well-adjusted.
- Sizing the cage for one bird, then adding a second without upsizing to the 24×18×24 in pair minimum.
- Letting seeds become the base of the diet instead of the smaller supplement they're meant to be.
- Adding nest boxes, huts, or other enclosed "cozy" furnishings without realizing they encourage hormonal behavior and egg-laying.
- Choosing bar spacing outside the 3/8 to 5/8 inch range, either a safety risk if too wide or an unnecessary expense if too narrow.

Enrichment, by priority

Chew toys

Wood and other bird-safe chew toys give a natural outlet for a beak that's built to gnaw.

Foraging

Hiding pellets or vegetable pieces instead of only using an open dish engages natural foraging behavior.

Toy rotation

Swapping toys every so often keeps the cage mentally engaging without a full teardown.

Supervised out-of-cage time

Time in a bird-safe room, always supervised, adds activity and variety beyond the cage itself.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Straining, fluffed posture, or tail-bobbing while breathing with no egg produced; repeated clutches beyond an occasional egg; open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or discharge; feather or beak abnormalities; feather plucking down to skin; lethargy or appetite loss.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Diet breakdown: pellets vs. seeds vs. vegetables
- ☐ Single bird or bonded pair, and breeding status
- ☐ Egg-laying history, if female
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening

Why housing and hormones come up first

Chronic egg-laying, egg binding, and a fair share of feather plucking cases in this species trace back to hormonal triggers, nest-like furnishings especially, more often than anything else. A vet will ask about cage setup and any nest box or hut before anything else for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
An occasional single egg, even without a mate present, that passes normally	Repeated clutches, or straining without producing an egg
Brief fluffed feathers while resting or settling in for the night	Puffed-up posture, lethargy, or tail-bobbing that persists through the day
Normal preening and occasional feather loss during a molt	Feather plucking down to bare skin
Quiet, settled behavior once the dark cycle begins	Open-mouth breathing, discharge, or wheezing at any time

Chronic egg-laying & egg binding

Chronic egg-laying

Cause: hormonal stimulation, often worsened by nest-like furnishings such as a nest box or "happy hut," extended light exposure, or in some cases even without a male present at all. **Signs:** repeated clutches beyond a normal, occasional egg. **Response:** a vet can advise on hormone-reducing changes to housing, lighting, and diet. Removing nest-like furnishings (see page 8) is usually the first and most effective step. **Recovery:** often improves over weeks once the trigger is removed, but it can become a recurring pattern if those triggers come back.

Egg binding

Cause: an egg that fails to pass normally, more likely in birds laying chronically, running low on calcium, or laying without a mate. **Signs:** straining, a fluffed-up appearance, tail-bobbing while breathing, and lethargy. **Diagnosis:** physical exam, sometimes an X-ray to locate the egg. **Response:** this is a life-threatening emergency requiring immediate vet care. Don't wait to see if it resolves on its own. **Recovery:** outcome depends heavily on how quickly treatment starts.

THIS IS AN EMERGENCY

A hen straining without producing an egg, or showing tail-bobbing breathing and fluffed lethargy, needs a vet the same day. Egg binding does not resolve on its own and can be fatal if left untreated.

PREVENTION

Skip nest boxes and happy huts entirely for a non-breeding bird, keep the photoperiod near the natural 12 hours of darkness a day, and watch for early signs of chronic laying before it becomes a pattern. See page 8 for the full housing rule.

PBFD, polyomavirus & respiratory disease

Three conditions worth knowing by name before you ever see them.

Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease (PBFD)

What it is: a viral disease affecting feathers and beak. **Diagnosis:** vet testing is required to confirm it, appearance alone isn't enough. **Reality check:** there is no cure. **Prevention:** limit exposure to birds of unknown health status, especially at pet stores, swaps, or when introducing a new bird to an existing one.

Polyomavirus

Who it affects: primarily young birds. **Signs:** feather abnormalities. **Prevention:** a vaccine is available, ask an avian vet whether it makes sense for your situation, particularly if you keep multiple birds or plan to add more.

Respiratory disease

Signs: open-mouth breathing and discharge. **What it can include:** a range of causes, one of which is psittacosis. **Response:** any of these signs warrants a vet visit rather than a wait-and-see approach.

PSITTACOSIS IS ZONOTIC

Psittacosis can pass from birds to people. If you or a family member develop flu-like symptoms after a lovebird's respiratory illness, mention the exposure to your own doctor.

Feather plucking & behavioral health

Feather plucking has both behavioral and medical causes, and they can look identical from the outside. Don't assume it's "just behavioral" without ruling out a medical cause first.

Behavioral causes

- Boredom
- Insufficient sleep
- Sexual frustration, often tied to the same hormonal triggers described on page 8
- A cramped cage

Medical causes

- Infections
- Mites
- Vitamin A deficiency

Diagnosis

Response: a vet visit helps distinguish which category you're dealing with. Medical causes need treatment; behavioral causes need a change to environment, sleep schedule, or interaction level. Guessing wrong wastes time on the wrong fix while the underlying cause keeps going.

START WITH THE BASICS

Confirm cage size (page 5), sleep schedule near 12 hours of darkness, diet (page 6), and daily interaction level (page 7) before assuming anything more complex. A surprising number of plucking cases trace back to one of these four.

Setup checklist & environment targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Cage sized correctly: 18×18×24 in single, 24×18×24 in pair
- ☐ Bar spacing 3/8 to 5/8 in, ideally 1/2 in
- ☐ Perches at varied heights, clear of the dishes
- ☐ Food and water dishes
- ☐ Single-vs-pair decision made deliberately (page 7)
- ☐ Pellet-forward food source lined up
- ☐ Fresh vegetable source lined up
- ☐ Plain, breathable cage cover for nighttime, not a nest box or hut
- ☐ Chew toys and at least one foraging option
- ☐ Avian vet identified before bringing your bird home

Environment targets

TARGET	RANGE
Household temperature	65 to 80°F, normal household range, no special heating or cooling needed
Photoperiod (darkness)	Roughly 12 hours daily
Cage minimum, single bird	18×18×24 in
Cage minimum, bonded pair	24×18×24 in
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (1/2 in ideal)

EASIER THAN MOST SPECIES TO HOUSE

Lovebirds don't need UVB, a basking spot, or supplemental heat. Normal household temperature works well. Where this species actually gets complicated is the single-versus-pair decision on page 7, not the environment.

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

Straining, fluffed posture, or tail-bobbing breathing with no egg produced · open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or discharge · sudden feather loss or plucking to bare skin · lethargy or collapse · prolonged refusal to eat

READING	TARGET
Household temperature	65 to 80°F, no special heating or cooling needed
Photoperiod (darkness)	Roughly 12 hours daily
Cage minimum, single bird	18×18×24 in
Cage minimum, bonded pair	24×18×24 in
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (1/2 in ideal)
Routine vet checkup	\$25 to \$50

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Diet breakdown, single bird or bonded pair status, egg-laying history if female, and when symptoms started.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Common color type	\$50 to \$150
Rare color mutation	\$200 to \$400+, exceptional individuals to \$1,000
Adoption	\$20 to \$100
Pellets (annual)	\$70 to \$110
Vegetables (annual)	\$80 to \$130
Toys (annual)	\$40 to \$70
Vet care (annual)	\$70 to \$120
Monthly ongoing	\$70 to \$125
Routine vet checkup	\$25 to \$50

Shopping list

- ☐ Cage sized correctly for single bird or pair
- ☐ Perches at varied diameters and heights
- ☐ Food and water dishes
- ☐ Chew toys and a foraging option
- ☐ Plain, breathable cage cover, not a nest box or hut
- ☐ Pellet-forward food and fresh vegetables

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Egg binding needs immediate vet care and costs more than the routine \$25 to \$50 checkup above. A small emergency fund matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Cage size and bar spacing are directly tied to the safety and hormonal issues covered in this package. Pellet-forward food quality matters more than saving a few dollars on a seed mix. Save on toys and décor before you save here.

First 30 days & days 31 to 90

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm cage size and bar spacing against page 13, not just "looks about right"
- ☐ Confirm your single-vs-pair decision matches what you actually brought home
- ☐ Schedule a wellness vet visit within the first two weeks

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ If keeping a single bird, begin building toward roughly 2 hours of daily interaction
- ☐ Establish a consistent pellet-forward feeding routine
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 19

Week 4

- ☐ Review weight and appetite trend from the Owner Log
- ☐ Confirm the daily interaction routine is one you can actually sustain long term
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 20

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the follow-up wellness check most avian vets recommend after initial setup
- ☐ Watch for early hormonal or egg-laying signs, especially if any nest-like item snuck into the cage (page 10)
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or droppings
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 20

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Straining, fluffed, tail-bobbing, no egg produced	Egg binding	Vet immediately (page 10)
Repeated clutches beyond an occasional egg	Chronic egg-laying	Vet, remove nest-like items (page 10)
Open-mouth breathing, discharge, wheezing	Respiratory disease	Vet promptly (page 11)
Feather or beak abnormalities	Possible PBFD	Vet testing (page 11)
Feather abnormalities in a young bird	Possible polyomavirus	Vet visit (page 11)
Feather plucking to bare skin	Behavioral or medical	Vet visit to distinguish (page 12)
Bonded pair ignoring the owner	Normal pair behavior	No action needed (page 7)
Single bird seeming withdrawn	Likely under 2 hrs/day interaction	Increase daily interaction (page 7)
Sudden weight change between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 19)

Daily, weekly, monthly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Fresh pellets, vegetables, and water
- ☐ Quick visual health check: eyes, feathers, posture, appetite
- ☐ If single bird, roughly 2 hours of interaction spread through the day

Weekly

- ☐ Wash food and water dishes thoroughly
- ☐ Spot-clean the cage and liner
- ☐ Weigh and log in the Owner Log

Monthly

- ☐ Full cage deep clean
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one toy
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess light exposure as daylight hours shift through the year, aiming for roughly 12 hours of darkness
- ☐ Watch for early hormonal or egg-laying signs around seasonal light changes (page 10)

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	APPETITE	DROPPINGS	ACTIVITY	EGG-LAYING

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady weight trend is the single best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a weight or appetite change before anything else is visible.

Equipment log

ITEM	LAST DONE	NEXT DUE
Perch/toy rotation		
Cage liner change		
Water dish deep clean		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ At least one chew toy appropriate to beak size
- ☐ At least one foraging option beyond an open food dish
- ☐ Perches at varied heights and diameters

Monthly review

- ☐ Rotate or refresh at least one toy
- ☐ Offer supervised out-of-cage time at least once
- ☐ Reassess whether perches still fit current body size and cage layout

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

REFERENCE

Glossary

<i>Agapornis</i>	The genus name for lovebirds, from Greek for "love bird."
Bonded pair	Two lovebirds that have paired with each other, socially and often for life. A bonded pair bonds to each other, not to the keeper.
Chronic egg-laying	Repeated clutches beyond a normal, occasional egg, usually driven by hormonal triggers.
Egg binding	An egg that fails to pass normally. A life-threatening emergency requiring immediate vet care.
Happy hut	An enclosed, tunnel-shaped sleeping tent. Should not be given to a pet, non-breeding lovebird.
PBFD	Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease: an incurable virus affecting feathers and beak.
Photoperiod	The daily light-and-dark cycle; roughly 12 hours of darkness is the target for this species.
Polyomavirus	A virus primarily affecting young birds, causing feather abnormalities; a vaccine is available.
Psittacosis	A zoonotic disease that can occur alongside respiratory illness in birds, transmissible to people.

Compiled from avian and veterinary sources, cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an avian-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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